



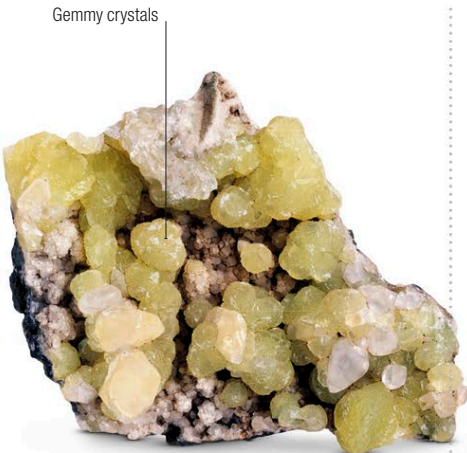
Prehnite

△ Grape-like prehnite crystal clusters on a rock groundmass

Prehnite is usually found as globular, spherical, or stalactitic aggregates of fine to coarse crystals. Rare individual crystals are often short and stumpy, and have square cross-sections, while some pale yellowish-brown fibrous material shows a cat's-eye effect when cut *en cabochon*. Prehnite is sometimes faceted, but the stones are almost always translucent rather than transparent; faceted stones tend to be small and are cut only for collectors and museums. Semi-transparent prehnite comes from Australia and Scotland, where the occasional near-transparent piece is found.

Specification

Chemical name	Calcium aluminium silicate	Formula	$\text{Ca}_2\text{Al}_2\text{Si}_3\text{O}_{10}(\text{OH})_2$
Colours	Green, yellow, tan, white		
Structure	Orthorhombic	Hardness	6–6.5
SG	2.8–2.9	RI	1.61–1.67
Lustre	Vitreous	Streak	White
Locations	Canada, Portugal, Germany, Japan, USA, Australia, Scotland		



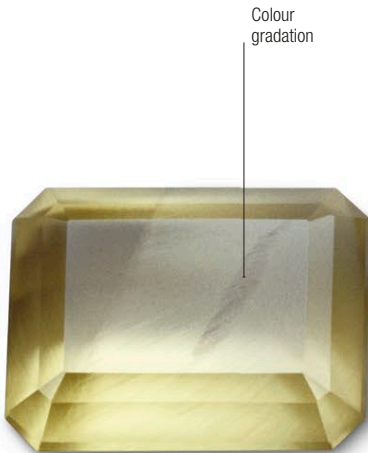
Gemmy crystals

Prehnite crystals | Rough | This specimen consists of a number of single crystals of prehnite of a yellowish colour, resting on a groundmass of rock.



Low dome

Square cabochon | Colour variety | Prehnite is not often found in light blue but, as can be seen in this translucent square cabochon, it can be a subtle pastel colour.



Colour gradation

Step-cut stone | Cut | Facet-grade prehnite is relatively rare, and is still somewhat cloudy when cut, as can be seen in this step-cut stone.



Rounded edges of table facet

Square cushion | Cut | The cloudy quality of this green, square-cut, faceted prehnite gemstone lends the gemstone a somewhat mystical appearance.

Colonel Hendrik von Prehn

The man who discovered prehnite

Prehnite was named after Colonel Hendrik von Prehn (1733–85), and was first described in 1788 at Cradock, Eastern Cape Province, South Africa. Information on Colonel von Prehn is scarce, but he is listed as commander of the military forces of the Dutch colony at the Cape of Good Hope from 1768 to 1780, and as the governor of the Cape Colony. He is also the reputed discoverer of the mineral that bears his name.



Battle off the Cape of Good Hope South Africa was the site of Anglo-Dutch military rivalry in the 17th and 18th centuries.



Polished beads

Prehnite beads | Set | These delicately polished prehnite beads consist of material that displays an unusually high level of transparency.